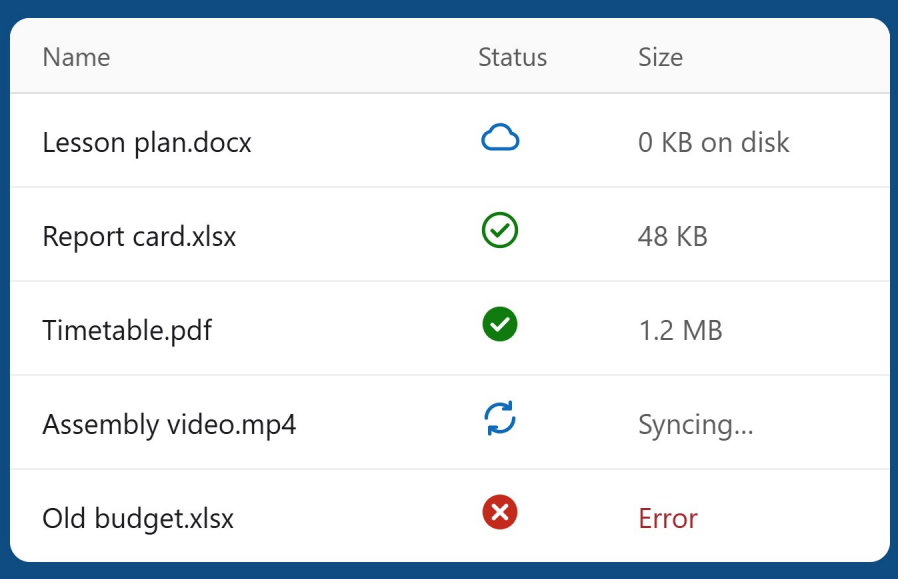
QUICK REFERENCE GUIDE

OneDrive Status Icons What they mean

The small icons in the File Explorer **Status** column, on the taskbar cloud, and on OneDrive on the web tell you where a file lives and whether it is syncing.



1 File Explorer – Status column

Shown next to each file and folder inside your synced OneDrive folder on a Windows PC.

Online-only

Uses disk space: No

Stored only in the cloud. Opens (and downloads) when you double-click it — needs internet.

Locally available

Uses disk space: Yes (for now)

Downloaded after you opened it; works offline. Can be turned back to online-only with *Free up space*.

Always keep on this device

Uses disk space: Yes (pinned)

You chose to keep it permanently on this PC. Always available offline.

Syncing / Sync pending

Activity

Uploading, downloading or waiting its turn to sync. If it never clears, check the taskbar cloud.

Sync error

Problem

This file or folder cannot sync. Click the taskbar OneDrive cloud to see the reason.

Padlock

Problem

Settings on this file or folder prevent it from syncing (shown next to the sync status).

Blocked file type

Work / school accounts

Your IT admin has blocked this file type from syncing — most often Outlook .pst data files.

Shared

Sharing

Shared with other people. A line under the icon means the file is also on this device.

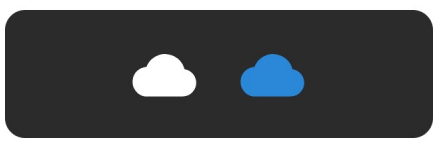
Shortcut (chain link)

Sharing

A shortcut to a folder someone shared with you (e.g. a SharePoint or colleague's OneDrive folder).

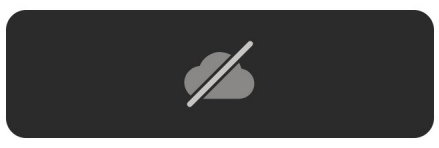
2 Taskbar – the OneDrive cloud

Bottom-right of the screen (notification area). A small badge on the cloud tells you the state of the whole account.



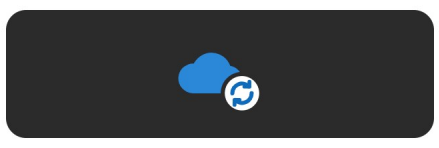
Signed in & up to date

White cloud = personal account. Blue cloud = work or school account. You may see both.



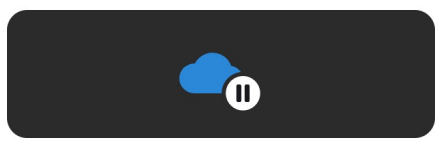
Not signed in

Greyed cloud with a line: not signed in, or setup not finished. Open OneDrive from Start.



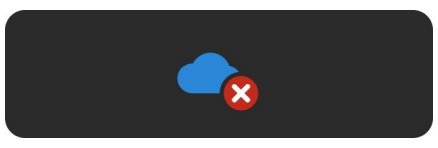
Syncing

Circular arrows: files are uploading or downloading, or OneDrive is processing changes.



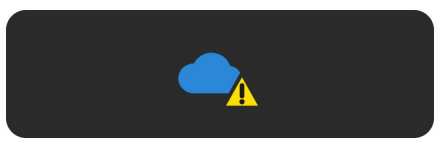
Sync paused

Files are not syncing. Click the cloud › Settings (gear) › Resume syncing.



Sync error

Something can't sync. Click the cloud to see which file and why.



Account needs attention

Yellow warning triangle — e.g. sign in again or storage nearly full. Click to read the message.



Account blocked

Red "no entry" badge: the account is blocked or frozen. Contact IT / Microsoft support.



Information

Blue "i" badge: tips or news about OneDrive features. Nothing is wrong.

3 OneDrive on the web (portal)

onedrive.com / Microsoft 365 in a browser. There is no Status column here — the cloud and green-tick icons only exist on a synced PC.

New item

"Glimmer" — three little blue lines next to a file or folder that is new.

Shared

Shown in the Sharing column when other people have access.

Syncing

Sync arrows can also appear online while an upload is still in progress.

Shared collection

Three squares next to an album: a shared collection of files.

Subscription & storage

Blue diamond on the toolbar (personal accounts): your plan and storage used.

Not OneDrive — a Windows glitch

These look similar but come from Windows itself. Fix: right-click the desktop › **Refresh**, or restart **Windows Explorer** in Task Manager.

- **Grey X on desktop shortcuts** — a corrupted shortcut icon, not a sync error.
- **Brown box over desktop icons** — a File Explorer display issue.
- **Shortcut arrow on normal files** — restart Windows Explorer.

Handy right-click actions

Need it offline? Right-click › **Always keep on this device** → solid green tick.

Low on disk space? Right-click › **Free up space** → back to blue cloud. The file stays safe online.

Red X or stuck? Click the taskbar cloud to see the error, then **View sync problems**.

No Status column? In File Explorer, right-click a column header › tick **Status**.

Source: Microsoft Support — "What do the OneDrive icons mean?" (checked October 2026). Icons are redrawn for illustration; exact appearance varies slightly between Windows 10 and Windows 11.